

God Knows Who You Are, and So Do You!

Luke 3:15-17,21-22

The people were waiting expectantly and were all wondering in their hearts if John might possibly be the Messiah. John answered them all, "I baptize you with water. But one who is more powerful than I will come, the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire. His winnowing fork is in his hand to clear his threshing floor and to gather the wheat into his barn, but he will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire." When all the people were being baptized, Jesus was baptized too. And as he was praying, heaven was opened and the Holy Spirit descended on him in bodily form like a dove. And a voice came from heaven: "You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased."

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Have you ever been confused with somebody else? Perhaps you look like your brother or sister, and your coach, your teacher, or your pastor called you by someone else's name? If that has happened to you, how did you respond?

Sometimes, it's just easier to go along with it. (Maybe you don't want the person to feel embarrassed.) But maybe you find a gentle way to correct the person. You might say, "I'm sorry, but you have me confused with someone else. My name is _____. " Then, maybe you give them a way to tell the difference.

The people in the days of John the Baptist were starting to get confused about who he was. They wondered if he was the Messiah (or, the Christ). They wondered if he was the promised Savior whom the Old Testament predicted. Did you catch how John the Baptist responded? He gently corrected them and pointed them to Jesus.

In today's Bible reading, the triune God gives us a clear way to know who Jesus is.

When John the Baptist baptized Jesus in the Jordan River, God the Father declared, "You are my Son." Then, God the Holy Spirit came down in the form of the dove that said, "I, the Holy Spirit, am with Jesus." This was God's way of making sure no one would get it confused. Jesus is the perfect Son of God, the Messiah, and the Savior.

In the same way, your baptism is God's way of making sure no one—including yourself—gets confused about who you are.

At your baptism, when splashes of water were put on you "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit," God declared you to be his perfect child. Ever since your baptism, Jesus has proudly declared you to be his brother or sister. The Holy Spirit promised, "I will guide you all the days of your life." Your baptism guarantees that God knows who you are.

And it helps you to know who you are. The next time you wonder who you are, the triune God—the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit—says, “I put my name on you. You are a Christian. You are my child, and I am well-pleased with you.

God knows who you are, and so do you!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- How is someone baptized?
- Who was at Jesus’ baptism?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- John the Baptist said that Jesus is “more powerful” than he was. What makes Jesus more powerful than John the Baptist?
- How does baptism change your identity?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- John the Baptist said that all people are either “the wheat” or “the chaff.” Which are you? And how do you know?
- Saint Luke tells us that Jesus was praying at his baptism. Because you are baptized, you can pray to God, too. Think of someone or a situation you want to pray for. Say a short prayer for them.

Closing Prayer:

Father in heaven, at Jesus’ baptism you made clear that he is your Son whom you love. Through your Holy Spirit, help us to remember that our baptisms have made it clear that we are your children whom you love. Amen.